BONUS 1 · INTERNOMICS

Conversation Teardowns

Internomics: How to See the Game Behind Every Interaction

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Conversation Teardowns

Bonus 1 · 9 real-life conversations, line by line, and the game underneath each one

You've learned the eleven models. Now watch them work.

Every conversation in this bonus is ordinary. A raise. A sales call. A fight about dishes. Nothing dramatic happens in any of them. That's the point. The game is always running. It just doesn't announce itself.

Here's how to read a teardown.

1. **Read the words first.** Cover the right-hand column. Read only what people said.
2. **Guess the game.** Before you look, ask yourself what's really going on. Which model would you reach for?
3. **Then read the right-hand column.** See what was happening underneath each line.
4. **Read the replay.** Same people. Same situation. One key turn played better.

Don't skip step two. The guessing is the training. Reading the answer teaches you the answer. Guessing first teaches you to see.

One rule for every replay. The better move is always an honest one. No tricks. No pressure tactics. Just a clearer view of the game and a smarter way to play it.

Teardown 1: The Raise That Became a Standoff

The setting: Maya has been at her company four years. She's good and she knows it. She walks into her manager Greg's office to ask for a raise.

Models in play: Model 1 See the Game · Model 2 See the Payoffs · Model 3 Think in Responses

Who	What they said	The game underneath
Maya	"Do you have a minute? I want to talk about my pay."	She's rehearsed her words. She hasn't mapped Greg's side of the game.
Greg	"Sure. What's up?"	—
Maya	"I've been here four years. I think I deserve a significant raise."	"Deserve" frames this as a fairness verdict. Greg now has to rule on her worth.
Greg	"You're doing great work. But budgets are tight this year."	A real constraint or a soft no. Maya can't tell yet.
Maya	"I hear that every year."	She hears an excuse. She never asks what the budget actually allows.
Greg	"I'm being straight with you. My hands are tied on base salary."	He named the exact constraint. "Base salary." There may be other levers.
Maya	"Well. I've had some interest from other companies."	Her one leverage move. She never asked herself the next question: then what?
Greg	"Okay. If you have an offer I'd want to see it."	Greg tests the claim. He may also start planning for her exit.
Maya	"It's not formal yet."	The leverage just turned into cheap talk. Her position is now weaker than when she walked in.
Greg	"Let's revisit this at review time."	The game ends with both of them worse off. She's frustrated. He's worried.

What went wrong

Maya played "me versus my boss." Greg was never her opponent. He likely wanted to keep her and was boxed in by budget rules. She missed his clue about base salary. Then she made a move without thinking one step ahead.

The replay

Who	What they said	The game underneath
Greg	“My hands are tied on base salary.”	Same constraint. This time Maya hears it as information.
Maya	“That’s helpful to know. What does have room this year?”	She shifts from “convince him” to “find the game we can both win.”
Greg	“Honestly? Bonus pool and title. Base is frozen until Q3.”	Now she knows his real payoffs and limits.
Maya	“Then could we look at a title change now and a base review in Q3? In writing?”	She builds an option that fits his constraint. “In writing” makes the Q3 promise real.
Greg	“I can take that upstairs. I think I can get it.”	He becomes her advocate. The game changed from standoff to shared problem.

The lesson: Most raise talks fail before the first word. You walked in with your payoff and never mapped theirs. **The question to carry:** What payoff would make their behavior make sense?

Teardown 2: "I Need to Think About It"

The setting: Tom sells project software to small firms. Linda runs operations at a twelve-person architecture practice. The demo went well. Then the close.

Models in play: Model 6 Map Information & Beliefs · Model 7 Separate Words From Credibility

Who	What they said	The game underneath
Tom	"So what do you think? Ready to get started?"	Tom assumes the demo answered her real questions. He doesn't know what she believes.
Linda	"It looks good. I need to think about it."	A signal with many meanings. Doubt about price? About the product? About her own authority?
Tom	"Totally. What's holding you back?"	A fair question. But it puts her on the defensive.
Linda	"Nothing really. It's just a big change for us."	She's not giving the real reason. Maybe she doesn't trust that he'll use it fairly.
Tom	"I can do fifteen percent off if you sign this week."	He guesses the problem is price. He never checked.
Linda	"That's generous. I'll let you know."	The discount answered a question she never asked. It also hints the list price was soft.
Tom	"Our clients usually see results in the first month."	Cheap talk. He benefits if she believes it. She knows that.
Linda	"I'm sure. Let me talk to the partners."	Here is the real game. Other players she never mentioned.
Tom	"Great. I'll follow up Friday."	He leaves with a lower price and no new information.

What went wrong

Tom treated "I need to think about it" as a price objection. It was an information gap. He didn't know what Linda believed or who else decided. His claim about results had nothing behind it. So it carried no weight.

The replay

Who	What they said	The game underneath
Linda	"It looks good. I need to think about it."	Same signal. This time Tom treats it as a question about her beliefs.
Tom	"That makes sense. What would you need to see to feel sure either way?"	He invites the real concern. "Either way" protects her freedom to say no.
Linda	"Honestly? Our last software rollout was a disaster. The partners are gun-shy."	Now he knows the real game. Past history. Two more decision-makers.
Tom	"Would it help to talk to a firm your size that switched last year? I'll give you their number. No script."	He replaces his claim with evidence she can check herself.
Linda	"That would help. And can the partners see it working on one live project?"	She designs her own proof. That's informed choice.
Tom	"Yes. Thirty days on one project. If it doesn't fit you walk away."	A trial lowers her risk. It also shows he believes his own claim.

The lesson: "I need to think about it" usually means "I don't believe it yet" or "I don't decide alone." Price cuts rarely fix either. **The question to carry:** What do they know or believe that I don't?

Teardown 3: The Meeting Where Everyone Agreed

The setting: A small company. Rachel owns it. Her sales manager Kevin and customer service lead Priya meet about an unhappy client who's threatening to leave.

Models in play: Model 10 Diagnose the Coordination Problem

Who	What they said	The game underneath
Rachel	"We can't lose Harmon. Someone needs to call them today."	"Someone" is no one. Nobody now owns this.
Kevin	"Agreed. They've been with us six years."	Agreement on the goal. Not on the action.
Priya	"Their complaint was about the last two deliveries."	Priya hints it's a service issue. Kevin may hear it as hers.
Rachel	"Right. So let's make sure that gets handled."	Another "let's." Each person hears a different owner.
Kevin	"Definitely. They need to hear from us."	"Us" could be sales or service. He's assuming service.
Priya	"Yes. Today if possible."	She's assuming sales owns the relationship.
Rachel	"Great. Glad we're aligned."	Everyone is aligned on the outcome. Nobody is coordinated on the move.
Rachel	(next morning) "Did anyone call Harmon?"	—
Kevin	"I thought Priya was on it."	Not laziness. Not opposition. A missing assignment.
Priya	"I thought sales owned the account."	Both made a reasonable guess. Both guessed wrong.
Rachel	"Why does nobody take initiative around here?"	She diagnoses character. The real problem is structure.

What went wrong

Nobody opposed calling Harmon. Nobody forgot. The group never set who was expected to act. Rachel then blamed people for a problem the meeting created. That story will make the next meeting worse.

The replay

Who	What they said	The game underneath
Rachel	"Before we leave. Who's calling Harmon?"	She checks for a shared expectation. Not just a shared goal.

Who	What they said	The game underneath
Kevin	“I’d say Priya. It’s a delivery issue.”	The hidden assumption surfaces in the room. Cheap to fix now.
Priya	“I can explain the delivery fix. But they’ll want to hear from their account lead.”	Real information. Both roles matter.
Rachel	“Then Kevin calls by 2 PM. Priya joins for the delivery piece. Kevin confirms back to me by 3.”	One owner. One time. One confirmation. Everyone knows. And everyone knows everyone knows.

The lesson: “We all agree” is not the same as “we all know who moves next.” Before you blame initiative, check the assignment. **The question to carry:** Are we actually in conflict or are we failing to coordinate?

Teardown 4: The Dishes. Again.

The setting: Sam and Jordan have lived together for three years. It's 9 PM. The sink is full. They've had this exact fight maybe forty times.

Models in play: Model 5 See the Equilibrium · Model 10 Diagnose the Coordination Problem

Who	What they said	The game underneath
Sam	"So are the dishes just going to sit there?"	Sam feels unappreciated. The complaint is a bid to be seen.
Jordan	"I was going to do them."	Jordan hears criticism. Defensiveness is the first step back.
Sam	"You always say that."	"Always" turns one evening into a verdict on character.
Jordan	"And you always do this. The minute I sit down."	Jordan's withdrawal is a response to Sam's push.
Sam	"Because if I don't say something nothing happens!"	Sam's push is a response to Jordan's withdrawal. Each move makes sense alone.
Jordan	"Fine. I'll do them now. Happy?"	Compliance with resentment. The dishes get done. The loop gets stronger.
Sam	"That's not the point."	It's true. The dishes were never the point.
Jordan	(silence)	Withdrawal. Which will produce more pursuit next time.
Sam	"This is why we can't talk about anything."	Each now has a story. "They're the reason we can't communicate."

What went wrong

Neither person is irrational. Complaint triggers withdrawal. Withdrawal triggers complaint. The pattern has become stable. Arguing better inside the loop just runs the loop faster.

The replay

The next morning. Not at 9 PM over a full sink.

Who	What they said	The game underneath
Sam	"Can we talk about last night? Not who's right. The pattern."	Sam steps out of the round and looks at the system.
Jordan	"Which pattern?"	—

Who	What they said	The game underneath
Sam	“I push when I feel alone with the chores. You pull back when you feel criticized. Then I push harder.”	Naming the loop out loud. No blame. Both moves are in it.
Jordan	“Yeah. And I really was going to do them. I just never know when ‘later’ becomes too late.”	New information. Part of this is a coordination failure. No shared rule.
Sam	“What if the cook doesn’t clean? And dishes are done before bed. No reminders needed.”	A convention. Both know the rule before the conflict starts.
Jordan	“Deal. And if I miss one, just say ‘dishes.’ One word.”	A light repair signal. Small slips don’t restart the war.

The lesson: When you have the same fight forty times it isn’t about tonight. It’s a pattern you both keep feeding. Change the pattern. Not the wording. **The question to carry:** What equilibrium have we created?

Teardown 5: The Curfew

The setting: Lisa's son Eli is sixteen. He wants to stay out until 1 AM on Saturday for a friend's party. Lisa's rule has been midnight.

Models in play: Model 2 See the Payoffs · Model 9 The Shadow of the Future

Who	What they said	The game underneath
Eli	"Can I stay out until one on Saturday? Everyone else can."	He's optimizing for independence. And for not looking like a kid.
Lisa	"Your curfew is midnight. You know that."	She's optimizing for safety. She states the rule. Not the reason.
Eli	"That's ridiculous. I'm sixteen."	He hears "I don't trust you."
Lisa	"And I'm your mother. It's not up for debate."	Authority as the argument. It ends the round. It doesn't settle the game.
Eli	"You treat me like I'm ten."	Now it's about respect. Not about one Saturday.
Lisa	"When you act like an adult I'll treat you like one."	No path is offered. What would "acting like an adult" even look like?
Eli	"Whatever. Fine."	He gives in today. He learns that asking openly gets him nowhere.
Lisa	—	Next time he may not ask. He may just text "phone died" at 12:40.

What went wrong

Lisa won the round and taught the wrong lesson. Eli learned that honest requests don't work. Both wanted something reasonable. Safety and independence. Neither said it out loud. And this is a game they'll play every weekend for two more years.

The replay

Who	What they said	The game underneath
Lisa	"I'm not trying to make you feel like a kid. Midnight is about me knowing you're safe."	She names her payoff. Now he can respond to the real thing.
Eli	"I know. But I'm the first one to leave every time. It's embarrassing."	He names his. Independence and status with friends.
Lisa	"Okay. What would make one o'clock feel safe to me?"	She invites him to solve her problem. That respects his autonomy.

Who	What they said	The game underneath
Eli	“I text you at midnight. Jake’s mom drives us home.”	He offers something he can be held to.
Lisa	“Deal for Saturday. If it goes well we keep doing it. If you miss the text we go back to midnight for a while.”	Conditional cooperation. Trust earned in steps. A clear path back after a slip.
Eli	“That’s fair.”	He now has a reason to keep his word. Next time matters.

The lesson: With people you’ll face again and again every answer is also a lesson. Ask what today’s response teaches them to do next time. **The question to carry:** What changes because there is a next time?

Teardown 6: The “Final Offer”

The setting: Priya buys packaging for a mid-sized food company. Her supplier rep Mark wants a nine percent price increase. They’ve worked together for five years.

Models in play: Model 4 Manage Predictability · Model 7 Separate Words From Credibility · Model 8 Commitment Changes the Game

Who	What they said	The game underneath
Mark	“Our costs are up across the board. We need nine percent.”	An opening number. Possibly padded.
Priya	“Nine is a lot. Could we do five?”	Fair counter. Same opening she’s used for five years.
Mark	“I can get to seven. That’s my final offer. I need an answer by tomorrow.”	“Final” and “tomorrow.” Two claims. Neither has anything behind it yet.
Priya	“Is that really final?”	Asking the person who benefits from “yes” whether it’s true.
Mark	“It really is. My hands are tied.”	Cheap talk. Saying it costs him nothing.
Priya	“Okay. I don’t want to risk supply. Seven it is.”	She concedes on the deadline. Not on the facts.
Mark	“Great. I’ll send the paperwork.”	—
Priya	—	Last year she also moved after “final.” Mark has learned a rule: pressure works on Priya.

What went wrong

Priya never tested what made the deadline real. She didn’t ask who decides or what happens after tomorrow. She folded the same way she always does. That pattern is now part of Mark’s strategy. Next year “final” will come sooner.

The replay

Who	What they said	The game underneath
Mark	“Seven is final. I need an answer by tomorrow.”	Same words.
Priya	“Help me understand the deadline. What happens after tomorrow?”	She asks what actually binds him. Not whether he means it.
Mark	“Well. Our pricing committee meets Thursday.”	The deadline is real. But it’s his internal schedule. Not a lost deal.

Who	What they said	The game underneath
Priya	“Then let’s give the committee something to work with. Can you share the cost breakdown? I’ll share our volume for next year.”	She trades information both ways. Credibility through evidence.
Mark	“I can send the materials index. What volume are we talking about?”	Now he’s checking her claims. That’s fair.
Priya	“Up twenty percent if the price holds at five. I’ll put the volume in the contract.”	Her own commitment. Written. Real. It makes “five” worth something to him.

The lesson: A deadline is only as real as what enforces it. And every time you fold to pressure you teach the other side to use more of it. **The question to carry:** What makes this commitment real?

Teardown 7: The Colleague Who Promised

The setting: Ben and Chris work on the same team. Chris promised Ben the client data by Monday. It's Wednesday. This is the third time this quarter.

Models in play: Model 9 The Shadow of the Future · Model 4 Manage Predictability

Who	What they said	The game underneath
Ben	"Hey. Any update on the client data?"	Polite. Indirect. He's avoiding the real subject.
Chris	"Oh man. Sorry. It's been crazy. I'll get it to you today."	An apology with no cost and a new promise with no backing.
Ben	"No worries. I know you're slammed."	Third "no worries." Ben is cooperating unconditionally.
Chris	"You're the best. Thanks for understanding."	Chris's payoff for missing deadlines with Ben: zero.
Ben	(to himself) "Unbelievable."	Ben's frustration is real. But Chris can't see it.
Chris	—	Chris has learned: Ben's deadlines are soft. Other people's are hard.
Ben	(Friday. To his manager) "Chris is completely unreliable."	Ben jumps from silence to a character verdict. No step in between.

What went wrong

Ben's kindness trained Chris to put him last. Then Ben swung from no consequence to a public complaint. Both moves are bad for the long game. One makes exploitation free. The other may punish what could be an honest overload problem.

The replay

Wednesday. Same moment.

Who	What they said	The game underneath
Ben	"Chris. This is the third deadline this quarter. I need to raise it."	Calm. Specific. No verdict on Chris's character.
Chris	"I know. I'm sorry. I'm being pulled four directions."	Possibly noise. Not malice. Worth finding out.
Ben	"I believe you. And I need to plan around what actually happens. What's a date you can truly hit?"	Leaves room for repair. Asks for a promise Chris can keep.

Who	What they said	The game underneath
Chris	“Friday noon. For real.”	—
Ben	“Friday noon works. If it slips again I’ll need to take it to Erin so she can sort out your workload.”	A boundary. Not a threat. It’s honest and he’ll actually do it.
Chris	“That’s fair. Friday noon.”	Now missing Ben’s deadline costs something. Keeping it rebuilds trust.

The lesson: Unconditional patience teaches people that your needs come last. Name the pattern early. Leave a clear path back. **The question to carry:** What does my predictability enable the other player to do?

Teardown 8: The Bad News That Came Too Late

The setting: Dana manages a product team. Last month a team member flagged a bug in a meeting and Dana snapped at him in front of everyone. Today Luis tells her a client launch will slip two weeks. He's known for ten days.

Models in play: Model 9 The Shadow of the Future · Model 3 Think in Responses

Who	What they said	The game underneath
Luis	"Do you have a second? The Westfield launch is going to slip."	He waited until he had no choice. That delay is data.
Dana	"Slip? How long?"	—
Luis	"About two weeks."	—
Dana	"When did you find out?"	A fair question. But it's really asking "who do I blame?"
Luis	"Around ten days ago. I hoped we could recover it."	Hope was partly true. Fear of last month's reaction was the rest.
Dana	"Ten days? I've told this team a hundred times. Bring me bad news early!"	Her words say "report problems."
Luis	"I know. I'm sorry."	—
Dana	"This is going to look terrible upstairs. I can't believe this."	Her behavior says "reporting problems is dangerous." Behavior wins.
Luis	(leaving)	Luis and everyone he talks to just learned when to bring bad news: as late as possible.

What went wrong

Dana is surprised nobody speaks up. But her team isn't responding to her words. They're responding to her history. Today she taught the lesson again. Next month's bad news will come even later.

The replay

Who	What they said	The game underneath
Luis	"The Westfield launch is going to slip about two weeks."	Same news.
Dana	"Thank you for telling me. Let's figure out what we can save."	She rewards the disclosure first. Focus moves to the fix.

Who	What they said	The game underneath
Luis	“I’ve known for about ten days. I should have said something sooner.”	He offers the hard part himself.
Dana	“I’d like to understand that. Was there something that made it hard to bring up?”	She asks about the game. Not about Luis’s character.
Luis	“Honestly? After what happened with the bug last month I wanted a fix first.”	The truth. Her past response shaped his move.
Dana	“That’s fair. I handled that badly. I’ll tell the team so too. Early news gets a thank-you from me. Every time.”	Repair plus a promise she can show in action. The next report is the real test.

The lesson: People don’t report on your words. They report on your last reaction. Every response to bad news teaches the team what to do next time. **The question to carry:** If I do this, what are they likely to do next? And if they do that, what will I do?

Teardown 9: Who Hosts the Holidays

The setting: Anna and her brother Mike both want the family together for the holidays. Their mother is now too frail to host. Anna wants it at her house. Mike wants it at his. It's October and nobody has booked anything.

Models in play: Model 10 Diagnose the Coordination Problem · Model 11 Change the Game

Who	What they said	The game underneath
Anna	"So I'm assuming everyone's coming to us this year?"	An opening claim dressed as an assumption.
Mike	"Actually we were thinking ours. We've got the bigger kitchen."	Both want the same thing. Everyone together. They disagree on where.
Anna	"But the kids' cousins are all near us."	A reason. Also a stake in her own preferred outcome.
Mike	"Mom's closer to us. That should count for more."	Each argument is true. None of them settles it.
Anna	"You hosted Easter."	Score-keeping enters. Now it's about fairness. Not logistics.
Mike	"That was two years ago."	—
Anna	"Let's just see what Mom wants."	Passing the decision to a player who doesn't want to pick between her kids.
Mike	"Fine. Ask her."	Mom will now be pressed by both sides. Worst seat in the game.
Anna	—	Weeks pass. Nobody books flights. The real risk: nobody gathers anywhere.

What went wrong

This isn't really a conflict. It's two people who want to coordinate and prefer different meeting points. Arguing which house is "better" can't end it. Each round of debate makes the next holiday's fight harder. And it pulls Mom into a choice she can't win.

The replay

Who	What they said	The game underneath
Anna	"Can I step back? We both want everyone together. We just want it at our own house."	She names the real structure. Shared goal. Different preferences.
Mike	"Yeah. That's about it."	—

Who	What they said	The game underneath
Anna	“What if we stop deciding this every year? We alternate. You this year. Me next year. Fixed.”	A rule both know before the next conflict. It changes the game, not just the move.
Mike	“I like that. And whoever isn’t hosting brings the main dish.”	He adds to the design. Both get a role every year.
Anna	“And Mom never has to choose. We just tell her the plan.”	The rule protects the person most hurt by the old game.
Mike	“Done. I’ll book the flights for Mom tonight.”	Clear owner. Clear next move.

The lesson: When two people want to end up together but prefer different places a fixed rule often beats winning the argument. Stop renegotiating. Redesign. **The question to carry:** Do I need a better move or a better game?

Your Turn

You've watched nine games. Now tear down one of your own.

Pick a conversation from the last two weeks that bothered you. One that went sideways. One that ended with nothing decided. One you keep replaying in your head. Short is fine.

1. **Write the words.** Fill in the first two columns as honestly as you can remember. What was said. Not what you meant.
2. **Leave the right column blank on the first pass.** Then wait an hour. Distance helps you see.
3. **Fill in the game underneath.** For each line ask what was really happening. What payoff was being protected? What was being learned? What wasn't said?
4. **Name the models.** Which one or two explain the most? Write them at the top. Then write the model's question.
5. **Write the replay.** Find the one turn where things went wrong. Rewrite it with an honest move. Then decide where you'll use it next time.

The setting: _____

Models in play: _____

Who	What they said	The game underneath

The turn that went wrong: _____

My replay: _____

The question I'll carry: _____

One last thing. You won't tear down every conversation. You don't need to. Do this a handful of times and you'll start hearing the right-hand column while the words are still being spoken. That's the whole skill.